Pass, after the army had made barely five miles' progress, 'thereby losing one more day', as Johnson noted.

> We had left Kabul with only 5 days ¼ rations to take us to Jellalabad, and no forage for cattle, and with no prospect of getting any.
>
> In this way he subjected our unfortunate troops, already nearly paralysed with cold, to another night in the snow with no shelter. No ground being again marked out for the troops, the whole was one mass of confusion. Three fourths of the Sepoys were mixed up with the camp followers and knew not where to find the HQs of their Corps.[34]

Lady Sale was equally scornful of the General's leadership, and became more certain than ever that a wholesale massacre was now imminent. She wrote:

> By these unnecessary halts we diminished our provisions, and having no cover for officers or men, all are perfectly paralysed with cold . . .
>
> The snow still lies more than a foot deep. No food for man or beast; and even water from the river close at hand difficult to obtain, as our people are fired on in fetching it; yet so bigoted are our rulers that we are still told that the sirdars are faithful, that Akbar Khan is our friend &c &c &c; and that the reason they wish us to delay is that they may send their troops to clear the passes for us! They will send them there can be in no doubt; but everything is occurring just as was foretold before we set out.[35]

So it was that for a second night the troops again went to bed hungry in the thick snow.[dd] This time, however, Afghans filled the slopes on all sides, shooting down through the darkness, and rumours spread that Akbar Khan was personally directing their fire. 'A night of starvation, cold, exhaustion, death,' wrote Eyre, 'and of all deaths I can imagine none more agonising than where a nipping frost tortures every sensitive limb, until the tenacious spirit itself sinks under the exquisite extreme of human suffering.'[36]

But the sufferings of the first two days were nothing compared with what would follow the next morning.

Butkhak lies a short distance beyond the towering cliffs of the Khord Kabul Pass.[ee] It was in the mouth of the pass, near here, more than two months earlier, that 'Fighting Bob' Sale's brigade had first been attacked as they were retiring for the night. Now the same cliffs were witness to a far more bloody dawn ambush. As before, the killing was preceded by the eerie ringing of unseen jezails loading.[37]